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School Transition Expectations of Newcomer Pupils in Germany: A Pilot Evaluation of a Summer Programme

Since 2015, over two million people have sought refuge and asylum in Germany.¹ Between January and August of 2022, the total number of first-time asylum-seeker applicants included close to 50,000 children under 18 years of age, which constitutes 42.9% of the total number of applications submitted to the *German Federal Office for Migration and Refugees* [Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge].² About half of those children (21.6%) were under the age of four. As a result of the large scale of this migration, newcomer pupils have faced challenges in accessing quality educational services. There are no reliable estimates of how many newcomer children and youth are enrolled in German schools. The *Expert Council on Integration and Migration* [Sachverständigenrat für Integration und Migration] estimates that about 130,000 refugee children and youth entered the German school system between January 2015 and March 2018.³ These newcomer pupils will continue to enter the school system in the future, which will significantly impact on the school system's resources and infrastructure. Research has documented challenges and needs related to providing quality education to newcomer pupils in Germany. Differing language backgrounds and related communication difficulties, and the fluctuation of newcomer pupils due to frequent changes of residence or deportation, are challenges in establishing supportive relationships with newcom-

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1 See Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge, "Aktuelle Zahlen, August 2022. Tabelle, Diagramme, Erläuterungen," Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge (Berlin), accessed December 19, 2022, <https://www.bamf.de/SharedDocs/Anlagen/DE/Statistik/AsylinZahlen/aktuelle-zahlen-august-2022.pdf>.

2 See Bundesamt für Migration und Flüchtlinge, "Aktuelle Zahlen".

3 See Sachverständigenrat Deutscher Stiftungen für Integration und Migration, "Schule als Sackgasse? Jugendliche Flüchtlinge an segregierten Schulen. 2018," accessed December 19, 2022, https://www.svr-migration.de/wp-content/uploads/2018/02/SVR-FB_Bildungsintegration.pdf.

er pupils and their parents.⁴ The high level of commitment of educators and cooperation with organisations offering extracurricular and out-of-school activities are important and beneficial in working with newcomer pupils.⁵

Many newcomer pupils have particular emotional needs due to their stressful journeys.⁶ Symptoms such as anxiety, insecurity, attention and concentration problems, aggression, and depression impact everyday school life.⁷ Furthermore, previous research has framed the process of entering formal education in a host society as a transition process in which children must negotiate multiple intersecting transitions (e.g., in family, friendships, community, and across language settings) that connect their home culture with the culture of the new school environment.⁸ Migration, be it voluntarily or involuntarily, can be perceived as a significant geographical but also psychological transition from one's home to another, potentially very foreign one. Moreover, transitions within the rigid structure of the school system pose additional challenges. Children must overcome the segregation between primary and secondary school and adapt to new structures, educational programmes, and social demands. Children may experience the transition from one school level to the next as an important shift, which might cause tension and anxiety.⁹ According to research by Nauck and Genoni in schools in the European Union,¹⁰ positive experiences of transition between educational levels, meaning

4 See Juliane Karakayali et al., "Forschungsbericht 'Solidarität im Wandel?'/ein Forschungs-Interventions-Cluster des Berliner Instituts für empirische Integrations- und Migrationsforschung (BIM). Kapitel 12: Die Beschulung neu zugewanderter und geflüchteter Kinder in Berlin. Praxis und Herausforderungen, Humboldt Universität zu Berlin," accessed December 19, 2022, accessed April 12, 2023, <https://digital.zlb.de/viewer/resolver?urn=urn:nbn:de:kobv:109-1-13840554>.

5 See Karakayali et al., "Forschungsbericht."

6 See Lutine de Wal Pastoor, "The mediational role of schools in supporting psychosocial transitions among unaccompanied young refugees upon resettlement in Norway," *International Journal of Educational Development* 41 (2015), accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1016/j.ijedudev.2014.10.009.

7 See Lauritz R. F. Müller et al., "1-year follow-up of the mental health and stress factors in asylum-seeking children and adolescents resettled in Germany," *BMC Public Health* 19 (2019), accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1186/s12889-019-7263-6.

8 See Julie Larran, Isabell Schuster and Sascha Hein, "The feasibility of implementing autism intervention methods in formal education settings welcoming refugee and asylum-seeking children: A systematic review of the literature," *New Directions for Child and Adolescent Development* 179 (2021): 7–28, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1002/cad.20449.

9 See Stig Broström, "Communication and continuity in the transition from kindergarten to school," in *Transitions in the Early Years*, ed. Aline-Wendy Dunlop, and Hilary Fabian (London: Routledge, 2002), 76–87.

10 See Bernhard Nauck and Andreas Genoni, "Status transition in the educational system and well-being of migrant adolescents in cross-national comparison," *Zeitschrift für Erziehungswissenschaft* 22 (2019): 47–69, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1007/s11618-019-00887-z.

that the child sees the transition challenge as manageable, are critical for children. In contrast, negative experiences of transition can produce lasting adverse effects. This is particularly significant for children from families with migrant backgrounds, putting them at risk, for instance, of dropping out of school.¹¹ Mackenzie et al. classify the potential challenges encountered in the transition from primary to secondary education into two groups: (1) Academic challenges (e.g., larger schools, different teacher expectations, and increased pressure); and (2) social challenges (e.g., higher need for social acceptance with the onset of adolescence and having to form new social groups).¹² Newcomer pupils arguably face a greater risk of being overwhelmed by the transition because they experience more significant difficulties than their native counterparts and may face additional difficulties such as language barriers, discrimination, and lack of resources.¹³ A study conducted with pupils in Berlin during the transition from primary to secondary school found that children will cope better with this critical life event if they can anticipate the new demands and requirements.¹⁴ This knowledge gives them a greater sense of well-being and resilience during the transition experience. Based on these observations, this study aimed to analyse how programmes for newcomer pupils may support their transition from primary to secondary school. Specifically, we conducted a pilot evaluation of a summer programme (Huckepack) aimed at supporting newcomer pupils before their transition from primary to secondary school in Germany.

11 See Rimantas Dumčius et al., “Study on the effective use of early childhood education and care in preventing early school leaving. Final report N° EAC/17/2012,” (Publications Office of the European Union: Luxembourg, 2014), accessed December 19, 2022, http://archive.erisee.org/sites/default/files/Study%20on%20the%20effective%20use%20of%20ECEC%20in%20preventing%20early%20school%20leaving_FINAL%20REPORT_0.pdf.

12 See Erin Mackenzie, Anne McMaugh and Kerry-Ann O’Sullivan, “Perceptions of primary to secondary school transitions: challenge or threat,” *Issues in Educational Research* 22 (2012): 298–314, accessed December 19, 2022, <https://search.informit.org/doi/abs/10.3316/aeipt.195502>.

13 See Frances Rice, Norah Frederickson and Joanna Seymour, “Assessing pupil concerns about transition to secondary school,” *British Journal of Educational Psychology* 81 (2011): 244–63, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1348/000709910X519333.

14 See Henrike Knoppick et al., “Das subjektive Erleben des Übergangs in die weiterführende Schule. Die Bedeutung der Antizipation für die Bewältigung dieses kritischen Lebensereignisses,” *Zeitschrift für Entwicklungspsychologie und Pädagogische Psychologie* 48 (2016): 129–143, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1026/0049–8637/a000152.

The “Huckepack” programme

Huckepack is a summer programme for newcomer pupils developed by the *International Rescue Committee* (IRC) in collaboration with *Teach First Germany* in 2020.¹⁵ The German word Huckepack translates into “piggyback” and underlines the programme’s focus on offering a safe space to learn with and from others. Huckepack is designed to be implemented all day over two weeks during the school break. The programme addresses several gaps pertaining to the transition to secondary school. First, one such gap is the general lack of responsibility of school authorities for pupils after they have completed elementary school and are not yet enrolled in secondary school. There is little to no communication between both schools, particularly over the summer holidays, when pupils are left without support and their parents may not know how to navigate the German education system. Second, because newcomer pupils may benefit from opportunities for social-emotional learning, Huckepack focuses on promoting pupils’ social-emotional skills, such as perspective-taking, self-awareness, and setting personal goals related to the transition to secondary school. This includes mindfulness activities, games, routines, and rituals in which the children experience an environment designed to help them feel safe to practice their skills with peers and caring adults. Huckepack is based on the IRC’s flagship programme, the *Refugee Youth Summer Academy* (RYSA).¹⁶ In an internal evaluation of IRC’s 2018 RYSA, pupils showed gains in academic performance in several school subjects, including social studies (+34%), math (+13%), and English (+9%).

A day in the programme typically looked like this: Children arrived at the school between 8:00 and 8:30 am. Every day started with breakfast in each learning group, and afterwards children participated in an energizer activity or a mindfulness exercise. The focus of the daily activities was on e-learning in 2020 and on physical activity in 2022. The afternoons were dedicated to exploring talents and

¹⁵ *Teach First Germany* is a not-for-profit organisation providing education to socio-economically disadvantaged pupils to support their transition into the German education system. To achieve this aim, *Teach First Fellows* are working at schools for two years while receiving supervision and professional development by *Teach First*. Fellows are university graduates from different backgrounds and disciplines. See <https://www.teachfirst.de/ueber-uns/>, accessed April 12, 2023.

¹⁶ The RYSA program is a six-week pop-up school in the United States (US). Students from grades 1 through 12 (high school) are invited to participate. The focus is on English language skills, mathematics, social science, and social-emotional learning. All students who have not previously attended a US school also receive a school readiness curriculum. Compared to RYSA, Huckepack has a stronger emphasis on social-emotional learning and on the transition from primary to secondary school.

building self-confidence. At the end of the afternoon, the children and adults came together for a final activity where everyone could share their feedback before the children headed home. One day a week was reserved for trips to the children's immediate surroundings so that they could explore their neighbourhood.

Huckepack is based on a theory of change, a set of methodological standards for conducting a theory-driven evaluation of the links between programme activities and intended outcomes.¹⁷ The programme developers created the theory of change and it outlines the key inputs, outputs (i.e., immediate results of the programme activities needed to achieve the program outcomes), and outcomes (i.e., intended and unintended changes arising from the programme outputs) as they relate to the overarching goal to promote social-emotional skills of newcomer pupils in preparation for the transition into secondary school. Outcomes include pupils' study skills (e.g., improved German language skills; age-appropriate/skill-sensitive input), social-emotional skills (e.g., coping with stress; perseverance/self-confidence), and school readiness (e.g., self-regulated learning). Importance was placed on ensuring that children were able and motivated to attend the program and that caregivers understood the programme's benefits and were both supportive and involved in the programme (e.g., arranging for transportation). Primary schools were informed about the goals of the program as well. Pupils were encouraged to form positive relationships with adults and peers to improve their self-esteem and self-confidence to cope with the challenges and opportunities of transitioning to secondary school. In 2022, the programme developers refined and expanded this theory of change to focus more specifically on physical activity, healthy habits, and mindfulness. These areas emerged as particularly requested by pupils according to anecdotal evidence during the implementation phase in 2020. Including these areas is, therefore, sought to enhance the pupils' acceptance of Huckepack. Expectations related to school transition remained a key aspect of the programme, as did self-esteem and peer relations. Huckepack encompasses various activities that allow pupils to reflect on their self-perceptions relating to the transition to secondary school, such as routinely reflecting on one's progressive achievements. Appreciating all participating pupils' strengths is a crucial component of the programme. Pupils were also encouraged to reflect on their educational aspirations and to discuss their goals with older pupils and educators/mentors. The scope and content of the Huckepack curriculum are similar to other summer enrichment programmes for newcomer pupils, particularly with programmes devel-

17 See Erica Breuer et al., "Using theory of change to design and evaluate public health interventions: A systematic review," *Implementation Science* 11 (2016): 1–17, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1186/s13012-016-0422-6.

oped in the United States. The literature on summer enrichment programmes for newcomer children and youth in general (not specifically focusing on the school transition), while based only on qualitative studies, generally has described positive results. For instance, the *Gateway Summer Enrichment Academy* is a four-week programme for refugee youth and other English learners and their families.¹⁹ The programme comprises an academic component and an enrichment component that includes activities in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics, sports activities like Zumba, music, and a drama programme. Attention is paid to parent outreach (e.g., by calling them once a week) and offering parent training sessions to provide information about the school system. Another qualitative study in Massachusetts reported that the programme helped to form trusting relationships with the parents.²⁰ The pupils expressed their desire to feel like they were part of something, and the programme created a sense of community and connectedness among the participants.

Another study implemented a summer enrichment programme with 218 secondary newcomer pupils with limited or interrupted formal education in 20 districts of New England in the USA.²¹ The four-week programme included an academic component (science and math, projects and presentations, English, science, and social studies classes) and an enrichment component (drama, dance, taekwondo, and science, implemented with another local non-profit partner). The qualitative analysis of focus groups with teachers, parents, and programme and district leaders, as well as academic and enrichment class observations, indicated that the programme served as a bridge between families and their district. The authors found stronger relationships between English language learners, teachers, and community-based organisations. Moreover, the authors concluded that the programme supported gains in English proficiency and, in addition to the academic component, addressed the socio-emotional needs of secondary newcomer students.²²

Although the studies cited above all claim to have recorded positive effects, this rather optimistic picture has yet to be substantiated by quantitative data in which measurable characteristics preferably of a large sample of pupils can be systematically compared before and after the completion of such a programme. To our knowledge, Huckepack is the first summer programme focusing on supporting newcomer pupils in the transition from primary to secondary school. Compared to other programmes, which focus on promoting language proficiency and academic skills, Huckepack emphasises supporting newcomer pupils' social-emotional needs.

The present evaluation of Huckepack

There needs to be more research on evidence-based programmes and approaches to providing supportive structures for newcomer children and their families as they transition from primary to secondary school. Therefore, we sought to answer the following research question: To what extent can a summer programme support newcomer pupils' transition from primary to secondary school? To answer that question, we had pupils fill in a questionnaire before and after participating in the programme. Here, we report on two pilot evaluations conducted in 2020 and 2022. Both implementations of the programme took place in Germany. The 2020 programme was implemented in a comprehensive school in Essen, a city in the state of North Rhine-Westphalia. In Essen, pupils transition from primary to secondary school after the 4th grade. In 2022, the programme was implemented in Essen and Cottbus, a city in the state of Brandenburg. In Cottbus, secondary school starts after the 6th grade. The analysis showed no significant correlations between the outcome variables and pupils' age. Therefore, the analysis combined samples from both locations. Both evaluations used a pre-post-test design in which children in the intervention group completed self-report measures before (first time point, T1) and after (second time point, T2) the programme. Based on the available literature and the goals of the theory of change, we expected significant changes in pupils' school transition expectations and, due to the focus on social-emotional learning, secondary effects on pupils' empathy, intercultural competence, motivation to learn, self-esteem, and well-being. Specifically, after participating in Huckepack, we expected that children, would perceive the transition to a new school as something to look forward to as it offered opportunities for personal, social, and academic growth. There was no control group in either 2020 or 2022 because no similar groups of pupils were available during the summer break.

Sample and measures used in the study

In 2020, 66 children (33 girls) attended Huckepack alongside 16 trained educators. Four groups were divided into two cohorts (eight groups in total). The first cohort participated in weeks one and two; the second participated in weeks three and four. Each of the eight groups consisted of six to ten children. All children took part at in least seven out of ten days. Thirty-four children (52%) attended on all days of the two-week programme; 16 children took part for four weeks. Thirty-one children were not born in Germany, and German was not their primary family language. Parents indicated 16 different countries of birth for their children and 17

different home languages. The main spoken languages besides German were Arabic, Turkish, and Farsi. The sample for this study comprised 50 pupils (23 girls) between nine and twelve years of age (average 10.37 years) whose parents provided their permission to participate in the research project. Of those, 48 pupils participated in T1, and 43 in T2. In 2022, 47 children participated in the evaluation, of which only 16 (eight girls) had data available at T1 and T2. Thus, while in 2020, a total of 43 pupils provided data we could use to probe mean changes over time, in 2022, the corresponding number was only 16.

Several self-report questionnaires were used to assess the children's outcomes before and after participating in Huckepack. Detailed information about all measures is presented in Table 1.

The implementation of Huckepack and data collection procedures

Huckepack was implemented twice – in 2020 as well as in 2022. The school boards and the local youth welfare offices supported the programme. In 2020, the IRC implemented the programme with “Fellows” from *Teach First Germany*. *Teach First Germany* is an organisation that supports teachers (“Fellows”) in working with newcomer pupils in German schools. To ensure that the pupils could easily understand the items, the measures used in this study were reviewed and pre-tested by professionals of *Teach First Germany*, who teach German as a second language. The questionnaires were administered online using individual tablet devices (in 2020) or paper-pencil surveys (in 2022). For participation in the summer programme, pupils were recruited using flyers and brochures with information about Huckepack, which were disseminated with the help of local partners. In 2020, parents could access a registration form (through a QR code of an internet link) that could be filled out in nine different languages. In 2022, parents registered using an online form they received over email. Parental permission was obtained once parents had filled in the registration form. The study protocol was approved by the ethics review committee at the Freie Universität Berlin.

Findings of the pilot evaluation of the Huckepack programme

Data were analysed using SPSS 29. At the end of the programme in 2020, 81% (34 out of 42) of the 2020 pupils and 62.5% (10 out of 16) of the 2022 pupils agreed or

strongly agreed that they had positive views on the social challenges related to the transition to secondary school, with a mean score ≥ 4 on expectations regarding social challenges. What's more, a total of 92.9% (39 out of 42) of the 2020 pupils, and 75% (12 out of 16) of the 2022 pupils agreed or strongly agreed that they had positive views on the academic challenges, with a mean score ≥ 4 on expectations regarding academic challenges. This finding indicates that the pupils had a positive expectation of the transition to secondary school and, on average, positive views of the challenges associated with this transition. In addition, at the closing session in 2020, 91.1% (41 out of 45) of the pupils agreed or strongly agreed that the adults in Huckepack took care of them and were responsive to their needs. Also, 70.5% (31 out of 44) of the pupils agreed or strongly agreed that they could talk about their problems with adults, and 84.4% (38 out of 45) agreed or strongly agreed that they know who can help when they have problems at school. While the percentages cited above may indicate that the programme was perceived as a safe and responsive place, they do not provide conclusive information about its effects.

We then analysed descriptive statistics of the main outcome measures. There were no statistically significant gender differences. In both 2020 and 2022, pupils generally reported high mean scores (i.e., above 4) across all outcomes at T1 except for extrinsic motivation to learn and social awareness, both of which are, however, over the response scale's midpoint of three. Following descriptive/preliminary analyses, the main aim of our study was to probe mean changes over time in the outcome measures using a total of 14 paired *t*-tests, respectively eight tests in 2020 and six in 2022. As shown in Table 2, the *t*-test generally did not indicate that participation in the Huckepack programme had the effects that we anticipated. In 2020, out of the eight changes in means between T1 and T2 that we expected, only one was statistically significant, in 2022 zero out of six.

Regarding the significant change over time, in 2020 the participating pupils reported higher levels of perceived academic challenges at T2 compared to T1, i.e., they were looking forward to the new academic demands. However, the magnitude of this effect was small. No significant effects were found for perceived social challenges, self-esteem, intercultural competence, empathy subscales, and extrinsic learning motivation. In 2022, none of the six outcomes significantly changed from T1 to T2. For example, neither of the two school transition expectations changed substantially.

Table 3 shows bivariate correlations between school transition expectations and social-emotional outcomes. In both years, perceived social and academic challenges were highly correlated. Moreover, social and academic challenges showed positive and statistically significant correlations with most outcomes. Extrinsic mo-

tivation to learn was the only construct unrelated to both aspects of school transition expectations.

Anticipation, strengths and concerns related to school transition

The analysis of answers to the three open-ended questions in 2022 provided qualitative data that indicated that newcomer pupils were mostly looking forward to meeting new peers and making new friends in their new school (21 answers). They also anticipated engaging with new teachers (5 answers) and school subjects (10 answers). Four pupils mentioned that they hoped not to be involved in conflicts at the new school. Other answers pertained to working with new schoolbooks, having fun, and going on school trips. When asked about their strengths that they could use in their new school, the majority of pupils (27 answers) referred to school subjects (e.g., mathematics) and related skills. Few children highlighted their motivation (2 answers) and social skills (3 answers). Finally, the pupils who indicated concerns related to their new school primarily mentioned bullying and conflicts (6 answers), lack of friends (3 answers), negligible German language skills (3 answers), and little or no support from their teachers (2 answers) as some of their concerns. Even if the open-ended answers cannot be used to evaluate the programme's effect, they gave an insight into the thoughts and reflections of some of the pupils who participated.

Discussion of the findings of the Huckepack evaluation

The main aim of this study was to evaluate the summer programme Huckepack aimed at supporting newcomer pupils before transitioning from primary to secondary school in Germany. Huckepack is a two-week extracurricular summer program developed and implemented by the *International Rescue Committee* in 2020 and 2022. Using a pre-post-test design, and comparisons of mean scores at T1 and T2 through *t*-test, we found that participation in the programme neither in 2020 nor in 2022 led to many statistically significant increases in the outcomes. However, perceived academic challenges rose significantly among the children who participated in 2020. This finding shows that children held positive views of the challenges associated with the school transition, including that they anticipated that the tasks in their new school would be fun and engaging, that they would learn

many new things, and that they would be able to show what they could truly do. In contrast, perceived social challenges (e.g., looking forward to a new school because they will be able to talk to and play with nice kids) did not change while participating in Huckepack. In the second iteration of the programme in 2022, no significant changes emerged at T2 compared to the ratings at T1 before the beginning of the programme. However, pupils reported higher levels of social awareness and well-being, specifically a positive outlook on their future, after participating in Huckepack. However, these increases were overall small and not statistically significant. Even if our results generally failed to indicate the expected positive effects of Huckepack, some findings may give direction for future research. Due to their positive correlations with school transition expectations, self-esteem, social awareness, and well-being could be promising entry points to supporting the transition process of newcomer pupils.

To our knowledge, Huckepack is the first summer programme focusing on supporting newcomer pupils in the transition from primary to secondary school. Thus, this study addresses, in part, the crucial gap in research on evidence-based programmes and approaches to providing supportive structures for newcomer children and their families as they transition within the German school system. Responsiveness to the needs of newcomer pupils is essential in light of vulnerabilities related to potential experiences of stress and trauma during the migration process.¹⁸ Irrespective of the results of the *t*-tests, the high retention rate and the anecdotal feedback from participating pupils indicate that Huckepack provided a safe space for social-emotional learning. Working with small groups of pupils was another strength in ensuring a high retention rate. Working closely with newcomer pupils over several weeks is probably important as a safe space for social-emotional learning.¹⁹

Strengths and limitations of the study

The study had several key strengths. First, the instruments were pre-tested and adapted by teachers who teach German as a second language, allowing for the questionnaire to be easily understood by the pupils. The data also indicated that

¹⁸ See Lutine de Wal Pastoor, “The mediational role of schools in supporting psychosocial transitions among unaccompanied young refugees upon resettlement in Norway,” *International Journal of Educational Development* 41 (2015), accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1016/j.ijedudev.2014.10.009.

¹⁹ See Pia R. Britto et al., “Pathways to a more peaceful and sustainable world: The transformative power of children in families,” *Development and Psychopathology* 33 (2021): 409–420, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1017/S0954579420000681.

pupils had no major problems in completing the questionnaire. Second, the questionnaires were administered in an anonymous and trustworthy environment. Also, the pupils seemed to enjoy completing the survey using tablet devices. Third, most of the pupils who provided data at both T1 and T2, i.e., 43 in 2020 and 16 in 2022 respectively, responded to all questions, with only few data missing. Together, these observations may indicate that the study design was generally well perceived and pupils were able to use the tablet devices with ease.

Some limitations were evident. First, the reliability (i.e., internal consistencies) of some scales (e.g., extrinsic motivation to learn) at the first measurement point was only acceptable. Additional research is needed to examine the psychometric properties of all scales to bolster confidence in interpreting the programme effects. Second, only self-reported measures were employed, and the mean scores of the scales were generally high (means ≥ 4). This might indicate a social desirability bias, a general problem with self-report measures. Thus, future projects should include observational and behavioural measures to comprehensively examine programme effectiveness using multiple methods and informants. Moreover, the lack of a control group limits confidence that the observed gains were related to Huckepack rather than general developmental processes. A randomised controlled trial may shed light on the causal impact of Huckepack on newcomer pupils' academic and social-emotional skills. The small sample sizes, particularly in 2022, are another limitation, which also limits the generalisation of the findings. Therefore, larger samples are needed to increase confidence in the study's findings. In addition, the test-retest method without a control group presents several weaknesses, especially over a short course of time, as in the present study. Although this method enables one to appraise mean differences over time, it is based on the assumption that the measured constructs do not change. Also, the participants may be familiar with the items at the second measurement, which may affect their responses. Hence, additional methods, such as qualitative interviews, should be used in future research. Finally, the differences in school systems in both federal states hinder the possibility of directly comparing and contrasting the pupils' outcomes across study sites.

Conclusion

Summer programmes that offer opportunities for academic and social-emotional learning, and that are culturally responsive to the needs of newcomer pupils may have the potential to provide much-needed psychosocial support during periods of transition. Being able to learn and test one's skills in a safe space with caring adults and peers is the foundation of Huckepack. The COVID-19 pandemic from

2020 to 2022 had a substantial impact on learning and well-being. Even though primary schools opened up before the implementation of Huckepack and managed to create a sense of a “normal” classroom setting right before the summer holidays, it was overwhelming for many children to deal with their school and social life in times of the pandemic. In part due to the pandemic, many children reported that they did not have the chance to see and visit their new school before the transition. Due to the small samples and the pre-post-test design, the general lack of statistically significant findings of this pilot evaluation is by no means conclusive. More studies using a similar design, although with much larger samples and control groups in place, are needed. Also, more in-depth, qualitative methods could be used to appraise the experiences of newcomer pupils during their participation in Huckepack. Using such methods would also allow for a more thorough understanding of the value of Huckepack after the transition to secondary school. Two possible entry points for such qualitative research are self-esteem, social awareness, and well-being, given the pupils’ self-reported (non-significant) growth in these areas.

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Table 1: Scales used to assess children's outcomes before (T1) and after (T2) participating in Huckepack in 2020 and 2022.

Construct	Scale	Subscale and number of items	Cronbach's α at T1	Cronbach's α at T2	Sample example items
School transition expectations	Impending Transition to Secondary School Perceived as a Challenge and Threat (ITCT) ²⁰	2020: Social challenges subscale: 4 items	0.86	0.81	"When I think of the fact that I will go to a new school next year then I look forward to it because I will be able to talk to and play with nice kids."
		2022: Social challenges: 6 items	0.94	0.95	
		2020: Academic challenges: 5 items	0.74	0.77	"When I think of the fact that I will go to a new school next year then I look forward to it because the new tasks will be fun for me."
		2022: Academic challenges: 8 items	0.93	0.95	
Empathy	Empathy Questionnaire for Children and Adolescents (EmQue-CA) ²¹	2020: Affective Empathy: 7 items	0.55	0.73	"If my mother is happy, I also feel happy."
		2020: Cognitive Empathy: 5 items	0.71	0.81	"When a friend is angry, I tend to know why."
		2020: Prosocial Motivation: 6 items	0.56	0.88	"If a friend is sad, I like to comfort him."

²⁰ Ulrike Sirsch, "The impending transition from primary to secondary school: Challenge or threat?" *International Journal of Behavioral Development* 27 (2003): 385–295, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1080/01650250344000082.

²¹ Sandy Overgaauw et al., "Assessing empathy across childhood and adolescence: Validation of the empathy questionnaire for children and adolescents (EmQue-CA)," *Frontiers in Psychology* 8 (2017): 1–9. doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2017.00870.

Table 1: Scales used to assess children's outcomes before (T1) and after (T2) participating in Huckepack in 2020 and 2022. (Continued)

Construct	Scale	Subscale and number of items	Cronbach's α at T1	Cronbach's α at T2	Sample example items
Intercultural competence	Multimodal Inter-cultural Competence Measure for Adolescents in Culturally Diverse Societies ²²	2020: Motivation: 6 items	0.90	0.87	"It's fun for me to interact with people from other cultures."
Motivation toward learning	Academic Self-Regulation Questionnaire (SRQ-A) ²³	2020: Intrinsic motivation: 5 items	Too low therefore subscale not used	Too low therefore subscale not used	Extrinsic motivation: "I work and study at school because I want to learn new things."
		2020: Extrinsic motivation: 4 items	0.57	0.67	
Self-esteem	Children's General Self-Esteem ²⁴	4 items	2020: 0.63	2020: 0.70	"I am proud of myself."
			2022: 0.78	2022: 0.94	
Social awareness	Student self-report of social and emotional competencies ²⁵	2022: 5 items	0.65	0.79	"In the last 2 weeks, how carefully did you listen to other people's points of view?"

22 Miriam Schwarzenthal, Linda P. Juang, Maja K. Schachner, and Fons J. R. van de Vijver, "A multimodal measure of cultural intelligence for adolescents growing up in culturally diverse societies," *International Journal of Intercultural Relations* 72 (2019): 109–121, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1016/j.ijintrel.2019.07.007.

23 Florian H. Müller, Barbara Hanfstingl, and Irina Andreitz, "Skalen zur motivationalen Regulation beim Lernen von Schülerinnen und Schülern. Adaptierte und ergänzte Version des Academic Self-Regulation Questionnaire nach Ryan und Connell," Alpen-Adria-Universität (2007), accessed December 19, 2022, https://ius.aau.at/wp-content/uploads/2016/01/IUS_Forschungsbericht_1_Motivationsskalen.pdf.

24 Ulrike Ravens-Sieberer and Monika Bullinger, "Assessing health related quality of life in chronically ill children with the German KINDL: First psychometric and content-analytical results," *Quality of Life Research* 7 (1998): 399–407, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1023/A:1008853819715.

25 Martin R. West, Katie Buckley, Sara Bartolino Krachman, and Noah Bookman, "Development and implementation of student social-emotional surveys in the CORE Districts," *Journal of Applied Developmental Psychology* 55 (2018): 119–129, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1016/j.appdev.2017.06.001.

Table 1: Scales used to assess children's outcomes before (T1) and after (T2) participating in Huckepack in 2020 and 2022. (Continued)

Construct	Scale	Subscale and number of items	Cronbach's α at T1	Cronbach's α at T2	Sample example items
Well-being	Stirling Children's Well-being Scale ²⁶	2022: Positive Emotional State: 5 items	0.84	0.93	"I've been feeling cheerful about things."
		2022: Positive Outlook: 7 items	0.87	0.96	
Open-ended questions	Developed by the study authors	2022: 3 questions			(1) "What are you looking forward to when you think of going to a new school?" (2) "Which of your strengths (things that you can do well) can you use in your new school?" (3) "Which concerns do you have when you think of going to a new school?"

Notes. With the exception of the well-being measure, all responses were made on a five-point scale ranging from one (*strongly disagree*) to five (*strongly agree*), and responses were averaged across the items to create the respective subscales. For well-being, response options ranged from one (*never*) to five (*almost always*) for positive emotional state and from one (*strongly disagree*) to five (*strongly agree*) for positive outlook.

²⁶ Ian Liddle and Greg F. A. Carter, "Emotional and psychological well-being in children: the development and validation of the Stirling Children's Well-being Scale," *Educational Psychology in Practice* 31 (2015): 174–185, accessed December 19, 2022, doi:10.1080/02667363.2015.1008409.

Table 2: Descriptive statistics

	Huckepack 2020					Huckepack 2022				
	Pre (T1)	Post (T2)	t	p	d	Pre (T1)	Post (T2)	t	p	d
School transition: perceived social challenges	4.54 (0.70)	4.52 (0.62)	0.19	0.851	0.03	4.29 (0.88)	4.26 (0.82)	0.30	0.766	0.08
School transition: perceived academic challenges	4.46 (0.67)	4.67 (0.49)	-2.47	0.018	-0.39	4.21 (0.73)	4.22 (0.94)	-0.04	0.971	-0.01
Self-esteem	4.32 (0.69)	4.47 (0.61)	-1.73	0.092	-0.26	4.06 (1.05)	4.17 (1.14)	-0.74	0.471	-0.19
Intercultural competence	4.13 (1.02)	4.37 (0.77)	-1.61	0.115	-0.26					
Affective empathy	4.02 (0.60)	3.96 (0.83)	0.56	0.581	0.09					
Cognitive empathy	4.31 (0.73)	4.32 (0.77)	-0.05	0.962	-0.01					
Prosocial motivation	4.74 (0.36)	4.61 (0.67)	1.73	0.092	0.28					
Extrinsic motivation to learn	3.05 (1.02)	3.14 (1.10)	-0.49	0.624	-0.08					
Social awareness						3.65 (0.86)	4.01 (0.74)	-2.07	0.056	-0.52
Well-being: positive emotional state						4.09 (0.98)	4.29 (0.87)	-1.31	0.213	-0.35
Well-being: positive outlook						4.22 (0.79)	4.43 (0.86)	-1.51	0.156	-0.40

Table 3: Correlations between the outcome measures at T1

	School transition: perceived social challenges	School transition: perceived academic challenges
School transition: perceived social challenges		0.75*** (0.75***)
Self-esteem	0.39** (0.68***)	0.43** (0.79***)
Intercultural competence	0.37*	0.53***
Affective empathy	0.25	0.35*
Cognitive empathy	0.17	0.34*
Prosocial motivation	0.54***	0.61***
Extrinsic motivation to learn	-0.13	-0.11
Social awareness	(0.54***)	(0.57***)

Notes. Pearson's *r* correlation coefficients (*n* = 44–45) with estimates for 2022 in parentheses (*n* = 47). * *p* < 0.05, ** *p* < 0.01, *** *p* < 0.001.